

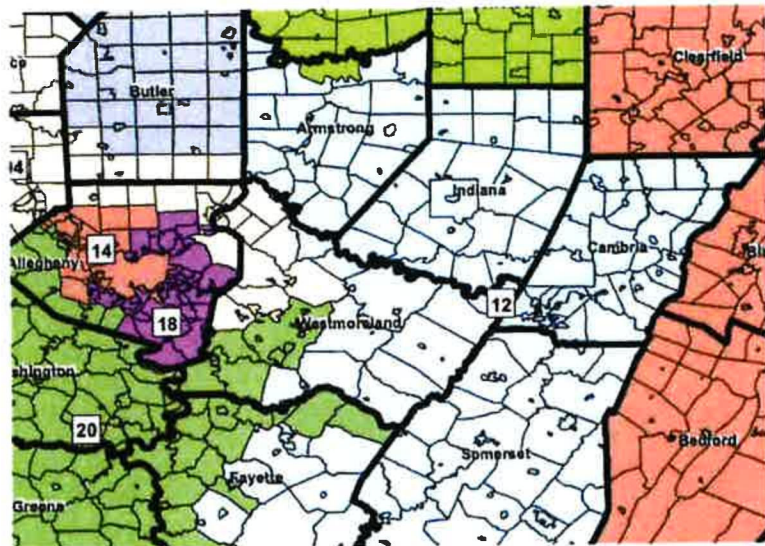
Testimony to the Allegheny Regional Hearing on Congressional Redistricting August 25, 2021 – Bridgeville, PA

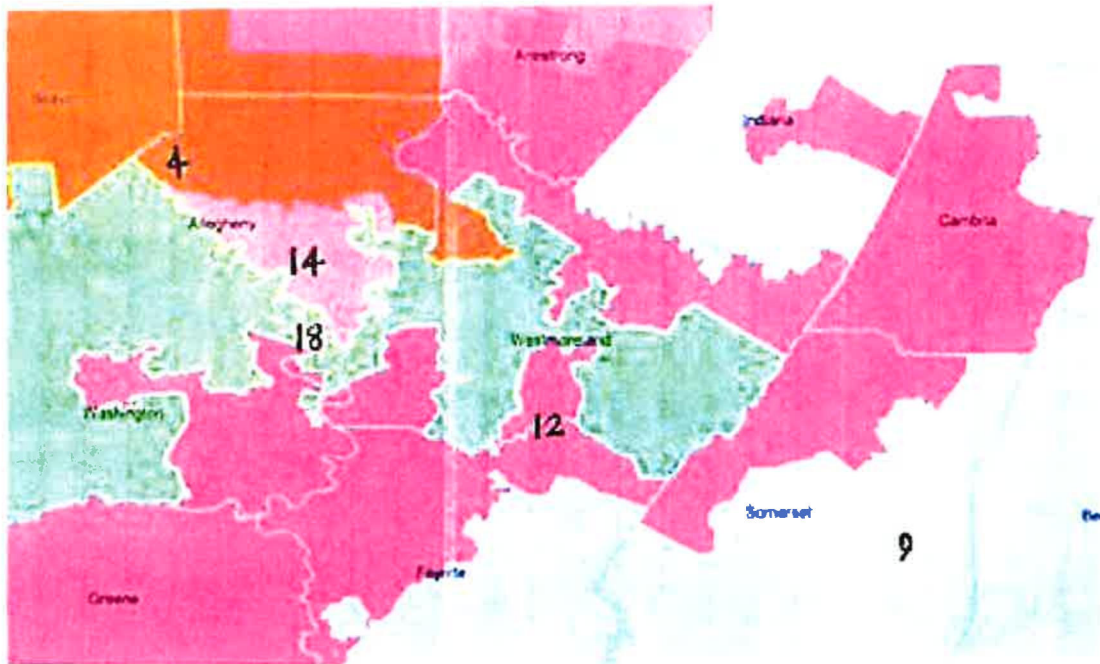


My name is Suzanne Broughton. I live in a retirement community in the Town of McCandless, north of Pittsburgh. I hold a master's degree in physics and have taught physics at the college level. In mid-career, I became a technical writer for computer software. I mention this personal history because both physics and computer science rely on well-defined and well-implemented processes to reach conclusions that accurately represent the data available. For a long time, I have also been interested in how a society's well-being is affected by the processes of government and their implementation – the good, the bad, and the ugly.

At the age of 84, I leave to younger generations the task of looking forward to the maps they want to see and will live with in their future. I'm sure you will hear from many of members of these generations. I would like to use my experience to sound a cautionary note with a look back at maps that I see as truly ugly examples of unfair processes that you should avoid.

I will trace the evolution of maps for one Congressional district over two redistricting cycles. The map on the right shows Congressional District 12 after the 1991 redistricting. The district included Armstrong, Indiana, Cambria and Somerset Counties and parts of Westmoreland and Fayette Counties. It was compact and reasonably shaped. Please also note the position of District 20 (dark green).

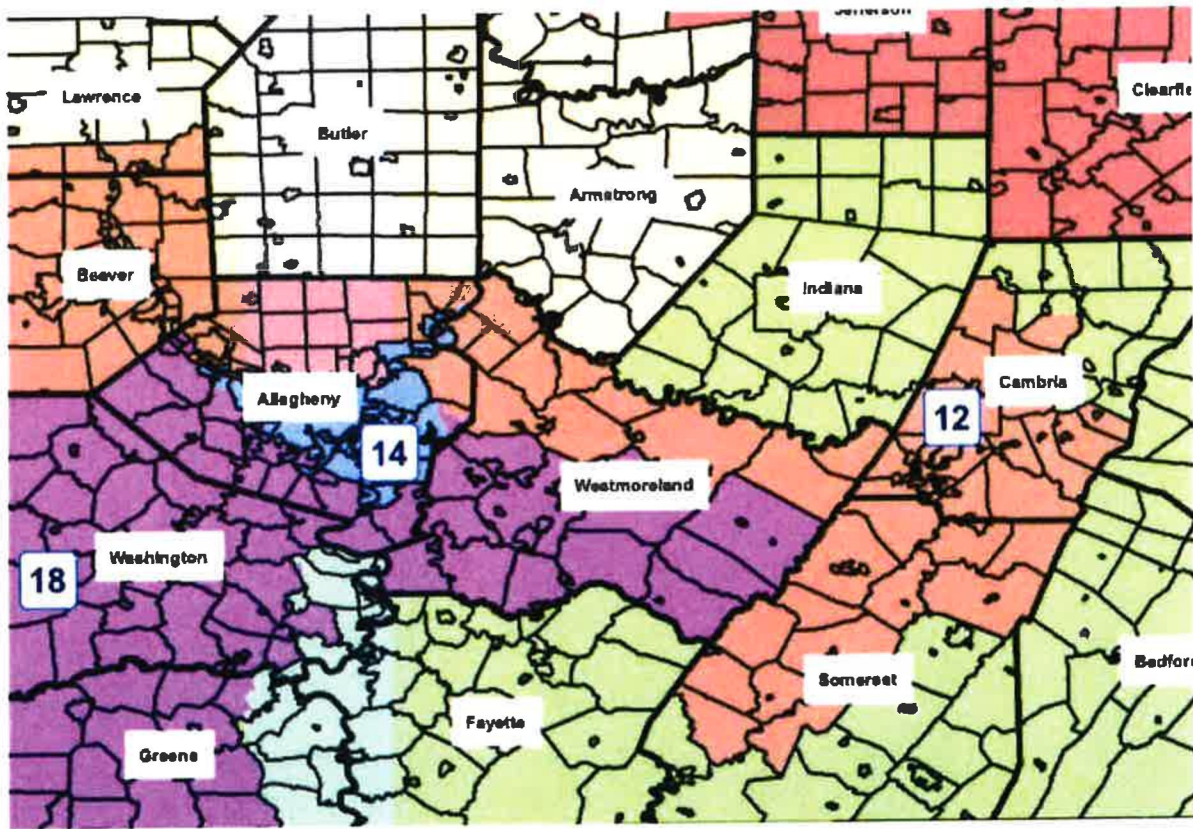




In 2000, Pennsylvania lost two congressional seats, from 21 seats to 19. The series of maps that I used on the previous and following pages had only a pencil-sketch type map with no color for 2001, (https://www2.census.gov/geo/maps/cong_dist/cd108_gen/ind_pdf/Pennsylvania/PA_CDloc.pdf?sec_ak_reference=18.7eac3817.1551608785.ecc0c255), so I have used the less-detailed map above.

To eliminate District 20 in the 2001 redistricting, the legislature stretched District 12, represented by John Murtha who lived in Cambria County, a long way to the southwest to encompass much of the old District 20, including the residence of Frank Mascara who had represented District 20. That gerrymander put Democrats Mascara and Murtha into the same district, forcing them into a primary contest to eliminate one Democrat. Did the legislative redistricting process really serve the constituents everywhere in this rambling, confusing District 12? Or did it only serve to enhance the power of the leadership of the majority party?

Murtha won, but he passed away in 2010, and Mark Critz was elected to his seat. In 2010, Pennsylvania lost another seat, down to 18. In the 2011 redistricting, the majority party no longer needed the area to the southwest. They could stretch District 18 and District 9 into most of it. They needed an area north of the city where they could again set up a primary contest between two Democrats. So, they moved District 4 to central PA to an area then in District 19, the number being eliminated.



This is where it gets personal for me. I lived in District 4, then in Franklin Park Borough (a triangle a bit north of the letter A in the word Allegheny on the map above). District 4 had been represented by Ron Klink, a Democrat; then Melissa Hart, a rather conservative Republican; and then Jason Altmire, a Democrat so moderate that his voting record was the most centrist in Congress. Voters had a real choice in each election for that seat. The 2011 legislature redrew District 12 to include much of District 4, including my home, setting up a primary contest between Critz and Altmire to eliminate another Democrat. Critz won. But the district was also made more Republican. The Allegheny Valley – the blue squiggle north of District 14 – had a history of voting Democratic due to union membership of workers in power plants and some industry. It was packed in with the Democratic voters in Pittsburgh, District 14, making their votes irrelevant, while almost splitting District 12 and making it more Republican. District 12 was won by Republican Keith Rothfus in November and in elections thereafter. I no longer lived in a competitive district.

So, how did the redistricting process produce these ugly, misshapen districts? A well-designed legislative process, implemented in good faith, should produce a fair map. But in Pennsylvania the legislative process is neither well-designed and nor fairly implemented. The rules by which both chambers of the Pennsylvania legislature operate allow a committee chair to unilaterally block a bill from being considered in committee and the majority leader to prevent a bill that is voted out of committee from receiving a vote on the chamber floor. So, any bill that might be introduced by a member of either party proposing a map not favored by the majority party leadership will not be considered. **The maps have been drawn by the majority party leadership with little consultation with their own members, none with the minority party, and no input from the public.**

This year, the legislature has made a significant step forward in consulting the public through these hearings, although with a few unsettling aspects. It is troubling that the two chambers are not holding joint hearings. It is even more troubling that information on the process is housed on partisan caucus websites. Why isn't there one easy-to-find, joint, **non-partisan** site for all information about this process?

So, here is your challenge. Open up this process. Make it easy for the public to follow and to participate. Work together across parties and across the two chambers of the legislature. Insist that the leadership must not control the mapping process. Then, **if the input from these and any subsequent hearings is taken seriously and shared with the Senate, if the proposals and suggestions of all members of the legislature are considered, and if hearings are held for the public to comment on the preliminary maps and the comments are taken seriously**, your legislature could indeed produce a map that fairly serves all the citizens of our Commonwealth.

I am looking forward to seeing that happen.

Thank you.